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Keep Talking and Nobody Explodes: Communication and Cooperation Under Pressure

Keep talking and nobody Explodes is a two player games where one player decodes a bomb, while the other guides them through it without seeing it. [5] It uses cooperative mechanics, UI separation and asymmetrical information to transform communication into gameplay to reinforce themes of trust, stress and collaboration through system design rather than narrative.

Communication isn't optional, it makes up the gameplay. One player has the visual of the bomb where they can view the modules and can actually interact with it, while the other can only view the manual which consists of dense instructions and charts. This acts as information asymmetry, which sets them apart from traditional puzzle games. Information asymmetry is when there is knowledge that is not shared between all players. [6] To overcome this, communication is necessary. Players with the bomb have to actively describe the module that they need to disarm. Their partner has to listen carefully and interpret what they hear. They then relay this information back by asking what they see to solve the puzzle. It is a constant back and forth of describing and questions. Clear communication is key and players are forced to depend on each other. The moment a miscommunication occurs, both players fail. It's not about being fast, it's about being precise and using communication as a tool.



Figure 1: The perspective with the bomb

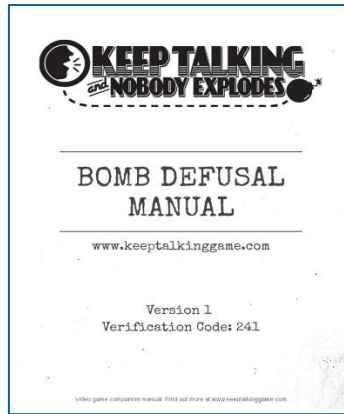


Figure 2: The manual with instructions

The game itself creates a high-pressure environment. One player visually sees the bomb. They can see the timers and the complex modules. This initial glance stresses the player out, as they must find a way to quickly and thoroughly describe what they see on screen to their partner. On the other hand, the other player cannot see anything and has to trust the information they receive. A more stressful environment results in lower linguistic complexity, meaning that players will struggle to talk to one another if they are under complete pressure. [7] This encourages players to find a way to adapt the way they speak under pressure by relaying information in an effective and calm manner. This situation also influences how decisions are made. They can choose the order in which they solve the puzzle and to move on if puzzles are too difficult. Over time, players naturally develop their roles. One person might be able to describe better and be precise while another will be good at sifting through the text heavy manual.

This game is fully based on trust. Players need to work with each other and trust the information that is being relayed between them. The puzzle can only be solved by working together, not individually. It also creates a platform for accountability. If one or the other miscommunicates, they can own up to mistakes. Team work also leads to innovative ways of outputting information. The longer you play with someone, the easier it is to understand what they are interpreting. Terminology becomes shortened and routines are created based on what module exists, thus optimising their gameplay and teaching cooperative literacy.

An example of adaptive language: One of the puzzles is a set of four symbols on a keypad. In the manual, there are columns of symbols. The player with the bomb must describe the symbols they see on the keypad. This is where they can use their adaptive language to describe the symbols, as many won't know the proper names of symbols. Their partner must look for a column that contains all four symbols. They must then communicate which keys get press based on the order of appearance. [8]

Keep talking and Nobody Explodes show how the game mechanics can reinforce them without using a narrative, by using information imbalance, time pressure and cooperation to convert communication into a mechanic. Players are forced to adapt to high pressure environments and learn to work together to find strategies and improve gameplay and redefine what a puzzle game is meant to be.